Same question. 25 seconds instead of 65 to 87.

Our test of CLAUDE.md, the house rules for one folder.

OUR TEST

"Give me the Monday overview of this export."

	WITHOUT	WITH CLAUDE.MD
Words	545 and 507	**149 and 111**
Seconds	65 and 87	**25 and 25**
Answer	Two different reports, with client tables and advice	The route table we meant, both times
Numbers	Right	Right

Same made-up export, two runs each. No run changed the file.

WHAT GOES IN

15 lines. Rules you can check.

```
# House rules for this folder

## What this folder is
A weekly shipments export from our transport
planning. The data is made up.

## Rules
- A week is an ISO week, Monday to Friday.
- BE-NL and NL-BE are two separate routes.
- Every number comes from the file.
- For the Monday overview, follow monday-overview.md.

## Never
- Never change or delete shipments-export-sample.csv.
- Never create a file unless I ask for one.
- Never send anything.
```

Shortened for the slide. The full file is in the kit.

BUT

It ignored one rule. Twice.

The rule: **"Start with a table."** What came first:

```
Run 1: Both weeks in the file are complete
       (Monday to Friday). ...

Run 2: ## Overview: ISO week 42 (12-16 Oct 2026)
       against week 41 (5-9 Oct 2026)
```

Anthropic: Claude treats CLAUDE.md as "context, not enforced configuration".

House rules guide. They do not lock.

THE FIX

A rule anyone can check, in a file for one job.

```
# monday-overview.md
1. Your first line is the table.
   No title or sentence before it.
```

One run: table first, biggest change first, then 3 lines.
One run is not proof.

GOOD TO KNOW

Short wins.

→ **/init** wrote us 26 lines that described the columns well. None of our rules. Keep two lines, add your own

→ **Under 200 lines,** Anthropic says. A 2026 study: context files raised cost by over 20% on average, and repository overviews in them did not help

→ **Folders above load too.** Our first test went wrong because of that

→ **Never** put passwords or client data in it

CLAUDE.MD FROM DAY ONE

Our harness: one workflow, 58 steps. Plan, build, test, open a pull request. Then up to five AI reviewers check it.

	TYPICAL START OF ONE STEP
My repo, before	162,168 tokens (the text Claude reads) before any work
My other repos	21 to 55 thousand, same workflows
My repo, now	57,581 tokens. About a third

The cause: every session loaded the rules for all my projects. 35 rules now load only when they are needed, and a test fails if they grow back.

House rules are not a file you write once. Keep them short, keep checking.

FREE FILES

Get the 15-line template. Free.

→ A 15-line CLAUDE.md template

→ The Monday context pack, and a blank one

→ What not to put in CLAUDE.md

→ Our /init output, to compare

On my profile, under Featured: AI Starter Kit, step 14. Save this post.

Tomorrow: make Claude Code ask before it changes anything, and undo a step.